L8 · MESA AI-NATIVE TRACK · C4

Build the Right Thing

How depth of understanding changes what you build.





Meera's LinkedIn Post Generator

"I don't get the bandwidth to convert my notes into LinkedIn posts"

→ *So what?*

"I'm not able to post regularly and build my brand on LinkedIn"

→ *So what?*

"I'm losing out on an important channel for my brand's growth"

→ *So what?*

"I'm losing out on Revenue"

This is the real problem worth solving.

Once you know the real problem, you know what to measure.

The chain said...	The wrong metric is...	The right metric is...
Posts aren't getting written	Number of posts published	Posting consistency (weekly cadence)
Brand isn't being built	Follower count	Profile visits from target audience
Channel isn't growing	Post likes and comments	Link clicks to product page from LinkedIn
Revenue is being lost	Engagement rate	LinkedIn-attributable purchases / conversion rate

The metric has to be traceable to the outcome. If it isn't, you're measuring the wrong thing — and building for the wrong thing.



Every job now expects AI fluency.

It's no longer a differentiator on your resume. It's a baseline requirement.

Every candidate on your shortlist will claim it.

A recruiter reading ten resumes can't tell who actually has it — and who just listed it.

The ones who can show their work get the shortlist. The ones who only claim it, get filtered.



Applying the ‘So What?’ ladder to your situation.

"Since every job now requires AI fluency, every Resume now claims AI fluency."

→ *So what?*

"A recruiter can’t tell the difference between a claim and a capability."

→ *So what?*

"I cannot differentiate myself from the 1000s of comparable resumes out there"

→ *So what?*

"I don’t get the interview - and I never get the chance to prove myself in the room."

This is the real problem worth solving.

What does solving this actually look like?

To get shortlisted for your dream job - by showing, not claiming.

The wrong metrics:

- Applications submitted
- Resumes sent
- Connections made

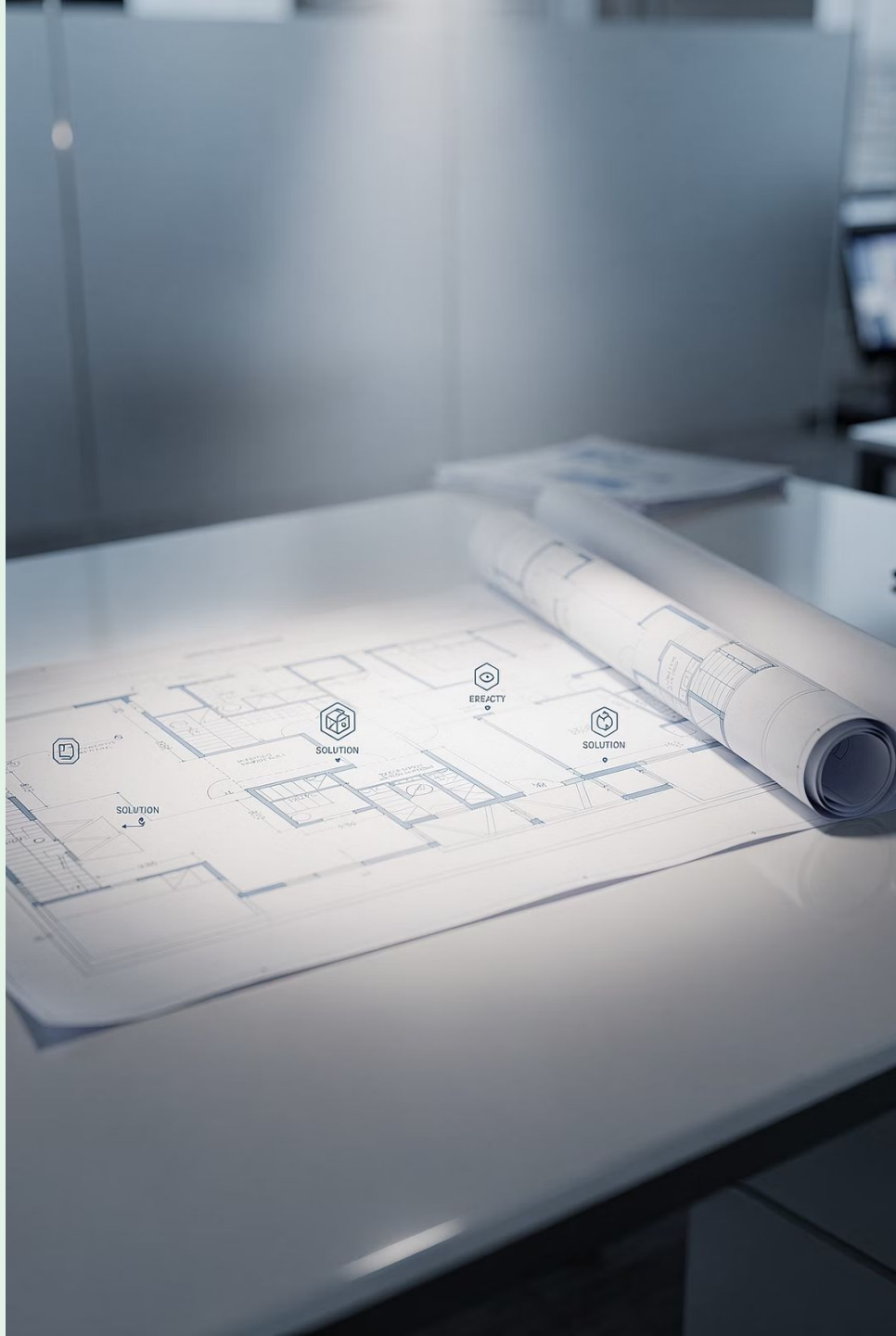
The right metrics:

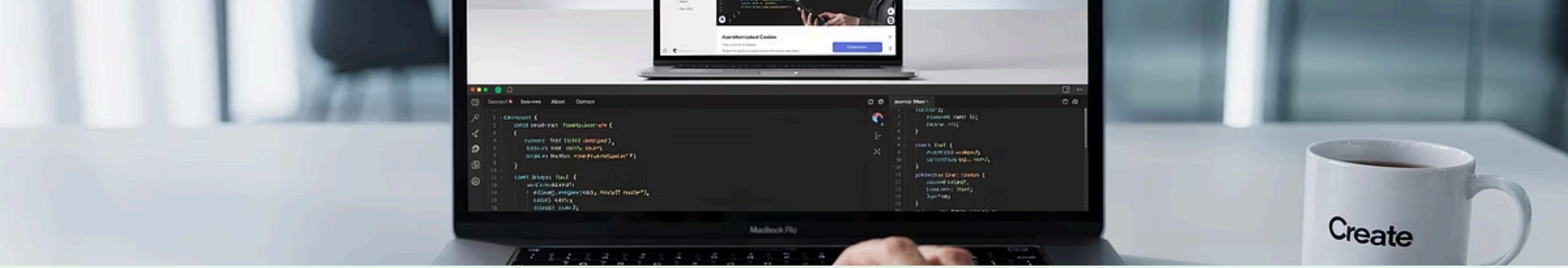
- Interview invite rate (shortlist rate per application)
- Unsolicited inbound from people who found your work independently
- Opportunities where your work was checked before the first conversation

If none of these are moving, the gap between what you can do and what people believe you can do is still open.

So what must the solution do?

- Must be findable and shareable - no friction, works from a resume or a cold message.
- Must show the work, not describe it - actual build, actual outcomes, actual numbers.
- Must be verifiable - they check it themselves, without you in the room.
- Must be permanent - lives after this cohort, after this semester.
- Must be yours - not a platform someone else controls or changes.





A personal portfolio website.

How different platforms serve different purposes in showcasing your capabilities:

A resume line	Says you have it. Can't prove it.
A LinkedIn profile	Algorithm-controlled. Doesn't show your actual build.
A portfolio website	Permanent. Shareable. Verifiable. Yours.

We didn't start with 'let's build a website.' The requirements got us here.

But wait - should the portfolio site BE your resume?

Option A: Direct Submission

Send the portfolio site URL/QR instead of a traditional resume. The work speaks for itself.

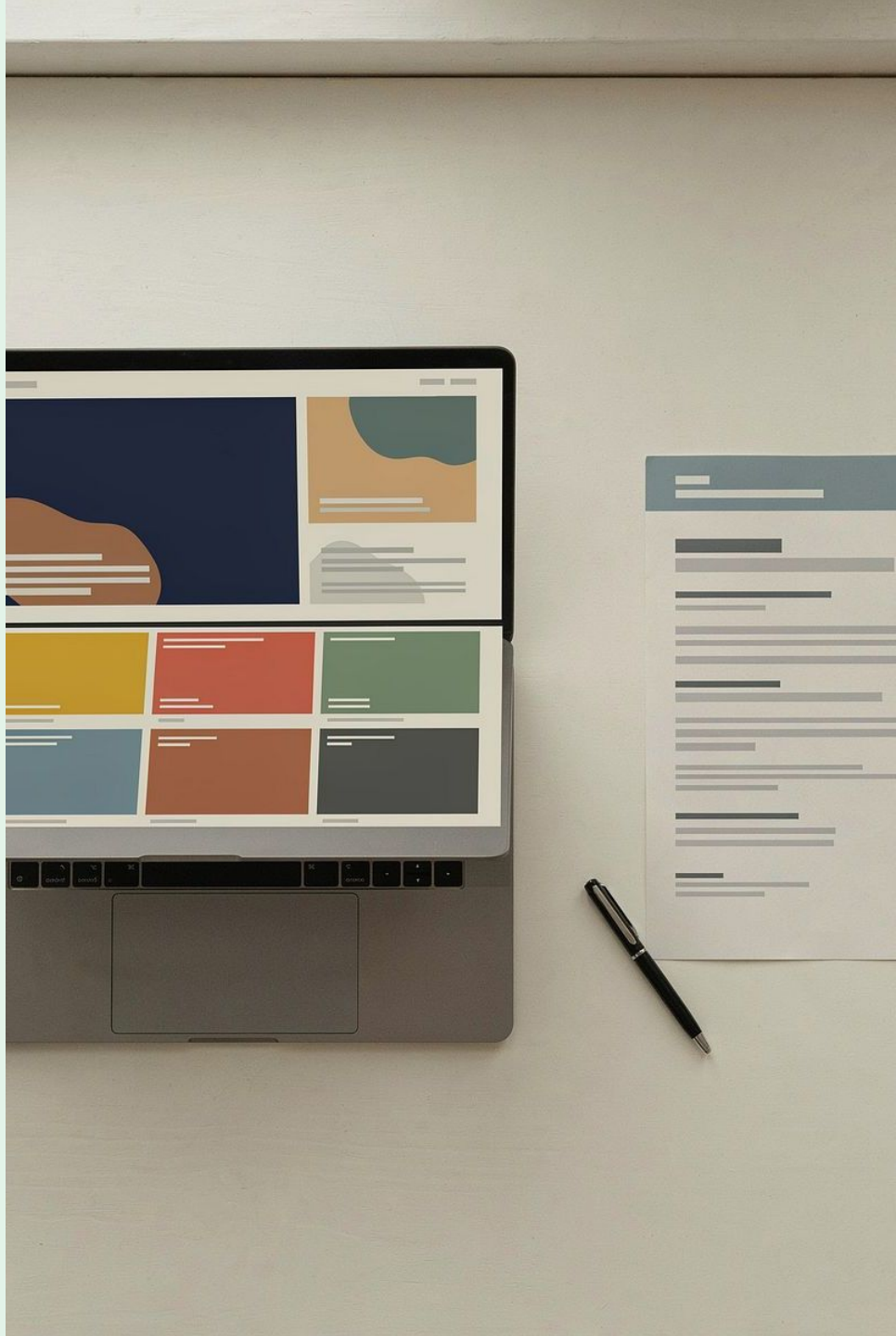
Option B: Supplementary Link

Keep a traditional resume. Add your portfolio site as a link inside it.



Here’s what the tradeoffs actually look like.

Portfolio as the resume	Portfolio as a link in the resume
Stands out - most candidates send PDFs	Passes ATS software - you’re in the human review pile
Works brilliantly for direct outreach to founders and early-stage teams	The link earns its click at exactly the right moment - when someone is deciding
The work IS the credential - no translation needed	Best of both worlds for formal applications
Most corporate ATS software can’t parse a URL - you get filtered before a human reads you	The link might never get clicked if the resume doesn’t spark interest first
Puts cognitive burden on the reader to navigate rather than scan	You’re maintaining two artifacts



The decision is yours. Here’s the frame.

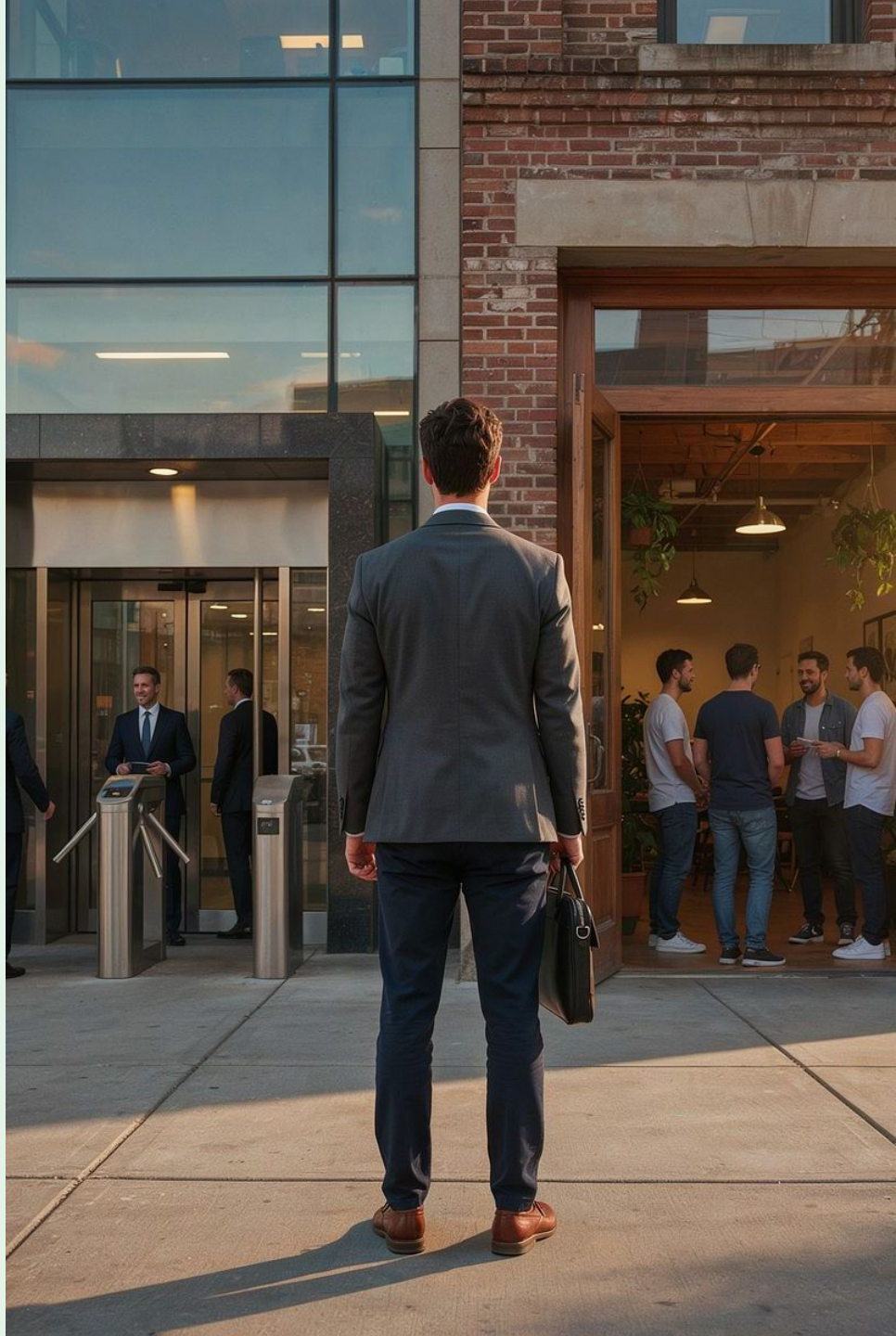
Formal corporate applications

Resume + portfolio link. Let the system work, then let the proof close it.

Startup outreach, founder conversations, cold messages

Lead with the portfolio. These humans are already AI-native. Show them first.

Both paths work. Neither works without the portfolio. So let’s build it.



The Nine Checks - Does This Deserve to Be Built?

⚡ Kill Switches

Any No means: don't build it.

- **01 Problem real?**
- **02 Workflow repeated?**
- **03 Input available?**

📊 Sizing

Any No means: build something smaller.

- **04 Output valuable?**
- **05 Impact measurable?**
- **08 ROI worth it?**

🚧 Boundary

Any No means: put a human exactly here.

- **06 Failure risk OK?**
- **07 Judgment protected?**
- **09 Owner clear?**

The Build - you've done this before.

1 **Components Map**

2 **First Prompt**

- One-line description of what you're building
- How it works
- Design philosophy

3 **v1 Build**

Getting live - you've done this before, too.

1 **Connect your Database**

Link your website/portfolio to a database - Supabase/Neon/Other

2 **Push to GitHub**

Create your repo in GitHub and push the code via Claude. Check .gitignore

3 **Deploy to Vercel**

Import your repo. One-click deploy. Vercel handles the rest automatically.



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